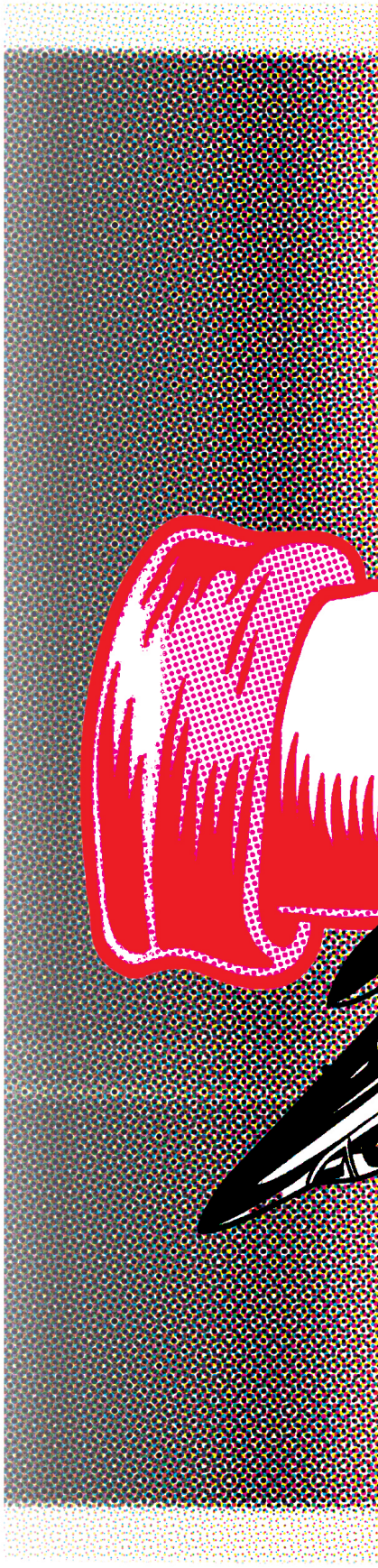


By VIJAY GOKHALE

THE TALK AND DETER APPROACH

INDIA SHOULD COLLABORATE BUT NOT LET CHINA HOLD ITS INTERESTS TO RANSOM



The successful conclusion of negotiations between India and China on the disengagement of military forces in disputed pockets of east Ladakh after more than 48 tense months marks the beginning of a process that might, hopefully, arrive at a new set of arrangements to manage the boundary dispute. Aside from the practical difficulties involved in negotiating a broader de-escalation in east Ladakh that guarantees equal and mutual security, working toward a mutual agreement on a new framework for peace and tranquility would also be a priority in the year ahead. Absent real trust, this might seem a difficult task, but there is mature leadership on both sides to take this process forward.

The normalisation of ties in other areas, including commerce and connectivity, has also been made possible by this thaw on the border. But the scars left behind by the Galwan incident might prove difficult to heal till India sees that China respects the sanctity of the LAC in all sectors. And, until then, the east Ladakh crisis, in the words of external affairs minister S. Jaishankar, makes India more likely to apply national security filters to economic decision-making. Defining and translating this idea into specific policy might, however, be the challenge. On paper, the substantial trade deficit in excess of $80 billion is a political concern, but the current options to reduce dependence are limited. Moreover, some of India's star exports performers, such as pharmaceuticals and textiles, are dependent upon Chinese machinery, raw materials or intermediary products. Taking a hatchet to the trade deficit in such sectors might amount to wielding it on one's own feet. A nuanced